

Hawk Roosting

- *Ted Hughes*



Edward James Hughes was an English poet and children's writer, known as Ted Hughes. His most characteristic verse is without sentimentality, emphasizing the cunning and savagery of animal life in harsh, sometimes disjunctive lines.

The dialect of Hughes's native West Riding area of Yorkshire set the tone of his verse. At Pembroke College, Cambridge, he found folklore and anthropology

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of particular interest, a concern that was reflected in a number of his poems. In 1956 he married the American poet, Sylvia Plath. The couple made a visit to the United States in 1957, the year that his first volume of verse, *The Hawk in the Rain*, was published. Other works soon followed.

Hughes stopped writing poetry almost completely for almost three years following Plath's suicide in 1963 (the couple had separated earlier), but thereafter he published prolifically, often in collaboration with photographers and illustrators, as in *Under the North Star* (1981). He wrote many volumes for children, including *Remains of Elmet* (1979), in which he recalled the world of his childhood. From 1965 he was co-editor of the magazine *Modern Poetry in Translation* in London. Some of Hughes's essays on subjects of literary and cultural criticism were published as *Winter Pollen* (1994). After decades of silence on the subject of his marriage to Plath, Hughes addressed it in the poems of *Birthday Letters* (1998). He was appointed Britain's Poet Laureate in 1984.

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Ted Hughes was the father of Frieda Hughes and the brother of Gerald Hughes.

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Summary

Hawk Roosting is a poem that puts the reader into the imagined mind of a hawk about to rest up for the day. It's a monologue of a raptor given the powers of human thinking, thus personified.

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It is a typical Ted Hughes animal poem, being unsentimental and unromantic. The poet concentrates on the dominance of the hawk as it sits in the wood reflecting on its *raison d'etre*, what it is and what it does.

Being at the top of the food chain this bird's instinct is to hunt down quarry; it lives by the deaths of other creatures; it kills in order to survive. It has no enemies except perhaps for humans so it does not fear life as other creatures further down the chain fear it.

Inspired by the rawness of the natural world, the speaker does not shy from explicit description. Some lines in the poem cause controversy because of their direct depiction of the hawk's instinctive behaviour.

Some commentators have remarked on the violence within. Ted Hughes had this to say:

'The poem of mine usually cited for violence is Hawk Roosting, this drowsy hawk sitting in a wood and talking to itself. That bird is accused of being a fascist, the symbol of some horrible genocidal dictator. Actually, what I had in mind was that in this hawk Nature was thinking. Simply Nature.'

So, there is this tension set up in the poem between what is instinctive, what can be observed in the natural world by anyone, and the mindset of the hawk itself, given human characteristics. Objective versus subjective. Biological versus political.

Ted Hughes first published Hawk Roosting in 1960 in the book *Lupercal* and it has been a popular poem since that time, appearing in many anthologies and on many schools and college curricula.

Analysis:

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Hawk Roosting is a poem that creates a special tension between the natural world and the human world, one that Ted Hughes explored a great deal in his animal poems.

This particular work relies on personification - the bird is speaking to itself, like a human - describing violent scenes, claiming domination, which means that the reader has to wrestle with ideas that go beyond the animal kingdom and into the realm of the human and associated psychological and political issues.

Some critics see in the ruthless behaviour of the hawk for instance, a despot or dictator, a figure that cares only about power, a symbol of the fascist. Ted Hughes never intended this to be the case but the way the poem is worded, detailing explicit violence and arrogant god-like thoughts, the reader can't help but entertain the idea.

The hawk, roosting in the top of a tree in a wood, is given a voice that is human and the ensuing monologue is an attempt to get right into the soul of the raptor and understand just what hawk essence is.

Using single sentences, lots of end stops (full stops), some enjambment and repetition, the stanzas are tightly controlled but given a sense of freedom by lack of rhyme and plodding beats.

STANZA 1

The first line is pure innocence. Here is the hawk settling down for a night's sleep at roosting time. The position he holds is secure - at the top of the wood, overseeing all. One thing for certain, this hawk has a mind of its own. It can think, like a human.

The second line gets the reader thinking too. That long four syllable word falsifying has repercussions. At this early stage there is no context for this word, which means to mislead, but it points toward comparison with humans, who are prone to misleading one another. This bird is pure raptor, can't be anything else.

Enjambment leads to line three and the repeated hooked just to emphasise that this hawk is physically

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impressive and sharp. And those hooked features might be called into action if the hawk falls asleep. Subconscious perfection of future hunts and kills.

STANZA 2

This hawk has it all worked out, from tree to earth, his physicality suits. Being high up means that there is an overview, a natural domination. The air's buoyancy (upward force) and warmth are there to be taken advantage of. Even the earth is facing the right way so close inspection comes as a given.

STANZA 3

Focus on the feet again as they close tight around the bark on the tree. Note the first lines of five of the stanzas are complete within themselves. End stopped. This means certainty and gives immediate control.

The theme of mastery continues, this time introducing the idea of the whole of Creation being within the grasp of this extremely dominant figure.

Lines 10 - 12 are a focal point in the poem for they suggest that Creation itself was involved in the making of this hawk and that now, the roles are reversed so to speak. It's the hawk that is holding Creation, becoming the master of all.

The question has to be asked: Is this the Creation of a Creator or the Creation of Evolution, where the fittest only survive?

STANZA 4

The perspective changes as the hawk continues its monologue, which is not a dream as we know it, but a live commentary.

Now the hawk is flying, watching the earth revolve as it makes its way up and up in readiness for a kill. That all-important four-letter word that first popped up in the opening stanza is here again - kill - I kill - that act which is so common and normal in the predator's world yet is so shocking and hard to handle in the human world.

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This is killing with impunity. The hawk has to hunt, it knows no other way and in the poem this fact is expressed with a certain coldness. The language is spare yet full of arrogance and fierceness. Everything belongs to the hawk when it is up in the air and ready to kill; there is no deception, no going back. Heads are torn off. Simple.

STANZA 5

The hawk deals out appropriate deaths, that is the purpose of the unwavering path when it is about to strike 'through the bones', a rather terrifying yet effective phrase.

There are no doubts or questions or debate or opinion one way or the other. Fact is fact; it's the whole thing. Nothing can get in the way of the hawk's instinctive actions. It kills without malice; the bird world's permissions are non-existent; environmental guidelines do not apply.

STANZA 6

All a hawk needs is the sun. Right now, the sun is setting. In the mind of the hawk nothing has changed, nothing ever will change. As long as the hawk has an eye, the all-seeing eye, its will to remain the same shall persist.

This last stanza sums up the hawk's attitude to life and death. In one sense it is a pure ego that is speaking - undiluted, pure, true to itself.

Having given the hawk a human voice Ted Hughes brings the raptor into the world of homo sapiens, that most developed of animals, the most sophisticated, able to consciously decide between the moral and the immoral.

In some ways the hawk becomes a mirror - reading this poem does make the reader think about life and death, power, morals, the relationship humans should have or want with, the natural world.

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What force compels the hawk? Evolution? A Creator? How does the personification change the way we think about this raptor, master of its own world, top predator?

SYNTAX AND LANGUAGE

Hawk Roosting is a free verse poem of 6 stanzas, all quatrains. There is no set rhyme scheme and the metre (meter in American English) varies from line to line. On the page it appears formal, tight, restrained - perhaps reflecting the balanced control of the hawk.

SYNTAX

Syntax is the way clauses, punctuation, grammar and sentences are put together and, in this poem, it is quite orthodox. There are no strange eccentricities, no odd line breaks or grammatical quirks.

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It gets the business of building a poem done, just as the hawk gets the business of living done - through ruthless control and efficiency.

Note the way many lines are end-stopped, again reinforcing the idea of strictness and straightforward action.

LANGUAGE/DICTION

Repetition and particular use of vocabulary help underline this poem's powerful message. For example, in the first stanza, the word *hooked* appears twice, so giving the feel of practicality and savage function. Raptors have incredibly sharp beaks (bills) and claws (talons) that absolutely get the job done.

And also, in the fourth line the phrase *perfect kills and eat* give the reader further food for thought with regards to what this bird is all about. The verb to *kill* occurs again in stanza four.

The idea that the hawk is invincible and made for one purpose gradually strengthens. Here is a bird in complete control, holding even Creation in its foot, pleasing itself as to whether to kill or not.

Suggested Reading

Thought Fox – Ted Hughes

The Windhover – GM Hopkins

The Eagle – Alfred Lord Tennyson

Raven – Edgar Allen Poe

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Kabuliwala

-Rabindranath Tagore



Rabindranath Tagore (1861-1941) was the youngest son of Debendranath Tagore, a leader of the Brahmo Samaj, which was a new religious sect in nineteenth-century Bengal and which attempted a revival of the ultimate monistic basis of Hinduism as laid down in the *Upanishads*. He was educated at home; and although at seventeen he was

sent to England for formal schooling, he did not finish his studies there. In his mature years, in addition to his many-sided literary activities, he managed the family estates, a project which brought him into close touch with common humanity and increased his interest in social reforms. He also started an experimental school at Shantiniketan where he tried his Upanishadic ideals of education. From time to time he participated in the Indian nationalist movement, though in his own non-

sentimental and visionary way; and Gandhi, the political father of modern India, was his devoted friend. Tagore was knighted by the ruling British Government in 1915, but within a few years, he resigned the honor as a protest against British policies in India.

Tagore had early success as a writer in his native Bengal. With his translations of some of his poems, he became rapidly known in the West. His fame attained a luminous height, taking him across continents on lecture tours and tours of friendship. For the world he became the voice of India's spiritual heritage; and for India, especially for Bengal, he became a great living institution.

Although Tagore wrote successfully in all literary genres, he was, first of all, a poet. Among his fifty and odd volumes of poetry are *Manasi* (1890) [The Ideal One], *Sonar Tari* (1894) [The Golden Boat], *Gitanjali* (1910) [Song Offerings], *Gitimalya* (1914) [Wreath of Songs], and *Balaka* (1916) [The Flight of Cranes]. The English renderings of his poetry, which include *The Gardener* (1913), *Fruit-Gathering* (1916), and *The Fugitive* (1921), do not generally correspond to particular volumes in the original Bengali; and despite

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its title, *Gitanjali: Song Offerings* (1912), the most acclaimed of them, contains poems from other works besides its namesake. Tagore's major plays are *Raja* (1910) [*The King of the Dark Chamber*], *Dakghar* (1912) [*The Post Office*], *Achalayatan* (1912) [*The Immovable*], *Muktadhara* (1922) [*The Waterfall*], and *Raktakaravi* (1926) [*Red Oleanders*]. He is the author of several volumes of short stories and several novels, among them *Gora* (1910), *Ghare-Baire* (1916) [*The Home and the World*], and *Yogayog* (1929) [*Crosscurrents*]. Besides these, he wrote musical dramas, dance dramas, essays of all types, travel diaries, and two autobiographies, one in his middle years and the other shortly before his death in 1941. Tagore also left numerous drawings and paintings, and songs for which he wrote the music himself.

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Kabuliwala Movie



Summary:

The narrator's precocious five-year-old daughter, Mini, started talking very young, and now she "can't stop talking for a minute." While her mother loses patience with Mini's chatter and "often scolds her," the

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narrator can't bring himself to tell her to be quiet because it is "so unnatural" when she's not talking. Because of this, Mini turns to her father when she wants to talk.

One morning while the narrator is working on the 17th chapter of his book, Mini approaches him and tells him that the gatekeeper doesn't know the proper word for a crow—he calls it "a kauyā instead of a kāk"—but the narrator realizes that she has actually misunderstood because the gatekeeper speaks a different language. However, before the narrator can explain this to her, Mini tells him that Bhola told her "an elephant in the sky squirts water through its trunk" to make it rain. Again, the narrator cannot answer her because she abruptly asks "what relation" her mother is to him. The narrator is unsure how to answer and so he tells her to go play, but she sits on the floor next to him and plays.

The narrator continues working on his book—an adventure story in which the main characters are escaping from a prison—but Mini suddenly catches sight of a Kabuliwala outside. He is dressed in "dirty baggy clothes" and carrying boxes of grapes. The narrator

thinks that the Kabuliwala "spells trouble" and laments that he won't get to finish the chapter he was working on.

Hearing Mini yelling about him, the Kabuliwala comes up to the house, but Mini suddenly becomes afraid that the Kabuliwala actually carries children in his bags, so she runs away to another part of the house. Not wanting to be rude, the narrator invites the Kabuliwala in and buys something from him while they talk about Afghani politics and the present conflict between the British and the Russians in Afghanistan. Although the Kabuliwala asks about Mini and the narrator calls her into the room "To dispel her groundless fears," she refuses to go up to him and instead eyes the Kabuliwala "suspiciously."

A few days after the Kabuliwala's first appearance, the narrator walks out of the house and sees Mini sitting and talking with the Kabuliwala, who is seemingly very happy to listen to her and tries to make himself understood in his "hybrid sort of Bengali." The narrator notes that besides himself, Mini has "never found so patient a listener." The narrator also notices

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that Mini is holding a pile of nuts and raisins, so he tells the Kabuliwala not to give her anymore and gives him half a rupee for what he has already given her before leaving.

Later, when the narrator gets back home, his wife is in the middle of scolding Mini for somehow getting her hands on a half rupee. Mini explains that the Kabuliwala gave it to her, and the girl's mother is upset with her for accepting it. The narrator "rescue[s] Mini from her mother's wrath" and brings her outside to talk. He learns that the Kabuliwala has been coming to the house almost every day, having won Mini's regard with presents of pistachios. They have become so close that they have inside jokes and the narrator comes to enjoy seeing them laugh together.

One of the jokes between Mini and the Kabuliwala—whose name is Rahamat—involves her eventually having to leave to go to her *śvaśur-bāri*. The narrator notes that while most Bengali girls Mini's age would know what this means, Mini does not because her parents are "progressive people" and thus have not talked much about her future marriage. In her ignorance, Mini always responds to Rahamat by asking

him if he is going to his, and he always shakes a fist at "an imaginary father-in-law" and makes a joke. Mini laughs at this, "imagin[ing] the fate of this unknown creature called a *śvaśur*."

The narrator notes that it is "perfect autumn weather," which makes him think about the "ancient times" when kings would "set out on their world-conquests." Unlike these kings, the narrator has never left his hometown of Calcutta. Because of this, his "mind roves all over the world" even while he is physically "condemned" to his house, and he loves imagining faraway places and "the free and pleasant life" he could have there. The Kabuliwala, who has traveled far more than the narrator, offers him an opportunity to hear stories about "High, scorched, blood-coloured, forbidding mountains" where "laden camels" and "turbaned merchants and wayfarers" can be seen traveling from one place to the next, which the narrator claims is "quite enough wandering for me."

The narrator's wife is very different from the narrator: she is "very easily alarmed" and is convinced that the world outside their home is dangerous and full of villains, life-threatening diseases, menacing animals,

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and even more menacing “white-skinned marauders.” Because of this, she repeatedly warns the narrator to keep an eye on the Kabuliwala. When the narrator tries to convince her that the Kabuliwala is safe, she launches on a tirade about the dangers of kidnapping and children being sold into slavery in Afghanistan. The narrator admits that his wife’s fears aren’t entirely unfounded, but he sees no problem in continuing to let the Kabuliwala come to the house to talk to Mini.

The time eventually comes for the Kabuliwala to collect his debts and return to his home. He is busy all day during this time, but never fails to come to the narrator’s house to see Mini. Even though the sight of Rahamat in his baggy clothes in “a little frightening” to the narrator, he is always overjoyed to see how warmly Mini greets the Kabuliwala.

One morning during this time, the narrator is up early and working in his study. He is enjoying the pleasant morning sun when he hears “a sudden commotion in the street.” From his study, the narrator sees “our Rahamat” being taken away in handcuffs, covered in blood. One of the policemen bringing him away is holding a bloody knife.

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The narrator goes outside to ask what happened and, between what the Kabuliwala and the policemen tell him, he gathers that a neighbor who owed Rahamat money refused to pay and so they got in a fight, during which he stabbed the neighbor. As he tells this story, Mini appears outside and goes up to the Kabuliwala just as usual. Mini asks him if he is going to his *śvaśur-bāri*, and he grins and says he is. However, in deviating from their usual script of inside jokes, the Kabuliwala fails to make Mini laugh. Gesturing to his handcuffs, he adds, “I would have killed my *śvaśur*, but how can I with these on?”

The Kabuliwala is sentenced to prison for many years, and the narrator and Mini soon forget him. As she grows up, Mini’s behavior, according to the narrator, is “not very praiseworthy” and the family’s groom, Nabi, soon “replace[s] [the Kabuliwala] in her affections,” and then after that Mini begins to prefer being friends with other girls her age. She also stops visiting the narrator while he’s in his study, and the narrator admits that “I, in a sense, dropped her.”

Years later, once again during autumn, the narrator and his wife arrange Mini’s marriage. They are

terribly sad to think that their “pride and joy” will soon be leaving their household for her husband’s. It is “a most beautiful morning,” but the narrator is feeling a lot of “grief” over the “imminent separation.” The house is very busy as preparations take place, but the narrator stays in his study to work. The Kabuliwala suddenly appears in the room unannounced and it is difficult to recognize him because his appearance has changed so much and he has lost his “vigour.” The Kabuliwala tells the narrator he had just been released from prison, reminding the narrator that he was “a would-be murder.”

The narrator nervously asks the Kabuliwala to leave because they are busy, but as he’s leaving the Kabuliwala asks to see the narrator’s “little girl.” The narrator believes that the Kabuliwala thinks Mini “was still just as she was” years before, the Kabuliwala has even brought some grapes, nuts, and raisins for her. The narrator tells him he can’t see Mini and the Kabuliwala prepares to leave again, but he asks the narrator to give Mini the treats he brought. The narrator tries to pay him, but the Kabuliwala tells him that he doesn’t want money and had come with his own daughter “in mind.”

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The Kabuliwala reaches into his shirt, “somewhere close to his heart,” and pulls out “a crumpled piece of paper” that has “a small handprint” made from soot on it. The Kabuliwala brings this “memento of his daughter” with him when he leaves home to sell fruit. With tears brimming in his eyes, the narrator says he “forgot then that he was an Afghan raisin-seller and I a Bengali Babu,” instead realizing that “he was as I am”: a father. The handprint on the paper, belonging to Rahamat’s “little mountain-dwelling Parvati,” reminds the narrator of his own daughter, and so he sends word for Mini to come down.

Mini comes down wearing her wedding clothes, which startles the Kabuliwala. After a moment, he addresses her as “Little one” and asks her if she is going to her *śvaśur-bāri*, but now that Mini knows what the word means, she is embarrassed. The narrator’s “heart ache[s].” Mini silently leaves the room. With a great sigh, the Kabuliwala sits on the floor, finally understanding “that his own daughter would have grown up too,” and he would have to get to know her again after his eight-year absence.

The narrator gives the Kabuliwala some money and tells him to go back to Afghanistan, and that by his “blessed reunion [with Parvati], Mini will be blessed.” The money he gives the Kabuliwala means that the wedding will no longer have “electric illuminations” or a live band playing. Although these upsets the “womenfolk,” the narrator believes “the ceremony was lit by a kinder, more gracious light.”

Analysis:

In Kabuliwala by Rabindranath Tagore we have the theme of connection, love, escape, trust, friendship, sadness and charity. Taken from his Collected Stories collection the story is narrated in the first person by an unnamed man (Mini’s father) and after reading the story the reader realises that Tagore may be exploring the theme of connection. Mini though at first afraid of Rahman gets to enjoy the time that she spends with him. She is intrigued by the goods he sells and rather than accepting the money for the purchased items. Rahman hands Mini back the money her father has given her. It is also noticeable that Mini’s father is very

much in love with Mini despite the fact that at times by being inquisitive she can be a handful. Most times Mini’s father plays along with Mini when she is asking questions as she knows all that Mini is doing is trying to learn. Mini’s mother on the other hand has less patience and does not like Mini asking so many questions. It is also interesting that Mini’s father likes to escape into different worlds, he is a writer after all. However, he always seems to be brought back down to life by family life.

There is also an element of trust in the story. By letting Mini talk and play with Rahman Mini’s father is trusting Rahman. Which may suggest that Mini’s father considers Rahman to be of good character. Mini’s mother on the other hand appears to be distraught that Mini is being allowed to talk to a person she knows nothing about. It is also noticeable that Rahman and Mini’s relationship is only fleeting. After Rahman has been sentenced to jail for seven years. Mini after a period of time and as other girls would do forgets all about her friendship with Rahman. However, despite the passing of time Rahman has never forgotten Mini. Something

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that is noticeable by the fact that he arrives to Mini's home on the night of her wedding. There is also a sense that Mini does not recognise Rahman. There is no talk of their past and the meeting between the two ends abruptly. This is more than hurtful for Rahman because he knows that he has a young daughter the same age as Mini in his village and she too most likely will not recognise Rahman. Tagore possibly deliberately adding an element of sadness into the story through Rahman's character.

Mini's mother is also an interesting character. Though she has little patience for Mini's continued talking she still nonetheless is concerned about her daughter. She knows what can happen on the streets of Calcutta and that Mini could easily be kidnapped. Though some critics might suggest that Mini's mother is overreacting it is most likely that she is just protecting Mini from the dangers of the streets. Mini's father on the other hand believes that Mini should be allowed to explore the world around her. To live her life to the best of her ability. Particularly when it comes to Rahman who has something that he can teach Mini. Rahman is

very much a man of mystery with his stories he can help enlighten Mini's already inquisitive mind. It is as though Rahman and Mini's friendship is a match made in heaven. Rahman though he may have attacked a man with a knife over an unpaid debt has never brought any danger to Mini or her family. He at all times has been polite and good-natured when it comes to his engagement with Mini and her family.

The end of the story is also interesting as Mini's father feels sympathy for Rahman. He knows that Rahman has a daughter and he knows that it is better for him to visit his daughter. The life he had previously lived in Calcutta is no more. So, the money Rahman receives from Mini's father is very helpful. It affords Rahman the opportunity to not only see his daughter again but there may also be a possibility that Rahman can become a Kabuliwala again. A life that reader knows Rahman very much enjoyed. It is also interesting that Mini's father feels good about his act of charity. Just as he is together with his daughter at Mini's wedding. So too can Rahman be with his daughter back in his village. Rahman will be able to put behind him

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the seven years he spent in jail and start a fresh life all over again. One that will include him getting to know his daughter all over again. Thanks to the charity of Mini's father who could have avoided Rahman and have asked him to leave the house. If anything, Mini's father has showed an altruistic streak when he did not have to. He was not made or pushed to help Rahman rather he choose to. Which leaves the reader suspecting that Mini's father is a good man. Who does not judge another person by their past. For Mini's father the future and what an individual does with their future is important.

Suggested Reading

Sweet Milk – Kamala Das

The Letter – Dhumaketu

The Postmaster – Rabindranath Tagore

Mashi - Rabindranath Tagore

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